

OUT OF LEFT FIELD

Oriole Manager Fits the Mold

By Stan Isaacs

You know the old story about the baseball manager deep down in the bush leagues? He has to be a fellow who can do everything. He's a manager, teacher, wet nurse, traveling secretary, ticket-taker and sometimes he drives the bus to the next town. And if the bus breaks down, he gets out and fixes it.

Earl Weaver, the new Baltimore manager who has spent almost half his 37 years in Stixville, U.S.A., says he never knew how to fix a bus. "The idea," he says, "is to have a first baseman who knows how to fix the bus."

Weaver is a welcome addition to the big-league managers' fraternity, and not only because he has replaced Hank Bauer. It's good to have him around because he is baseball's oldest kind of warm story, the man who gets a chance in the big leagues after a lifetime of toiling in the minors. He is the honest laborer, the man who has gotten dirt on his uniform while learning his craft. It shows these days in the way the Orioles are playing heads-up, action baseball.

Earl Weaver is Earl Weaver, but he's also Billy Jorges, Frankie Frisch, Joe McCarthy, Bill Rigney, Alvin Dark, Bobby Bragan, Charles Dressen, Gene Mauch, Solly Hemus and Eddie Stanky—meaning he's a little, middle-of-the-diamond infielder who has made it as a manager.

Weaver is like Casey Stengel in that he knows names, places. He played ball under Andy Cohen, the guy who replaced Rogers Hornsby as Giant second baseman in the 1920s; he was hit in the back twice by Bob Turley in the first professional game Turley ever pitched; he can tell you what it's like in Bublin, Ga. ("It's hot with big horseflies and lots of gnats").

The highest Earl Weaver got was to spring training camp with the Cardinals when Eddie Stanky was the manager. He played second base every day for almost two weeks. Then Red Schoendienst finished nursing an injury and Weaver found himself on the bench with the keen realization that there would be no place for him in the big leagues. "I thought I was good enough, but I could see they didn't think so."

One day before he left, he sat on the bench as Wally Westlake struck out. Weaver, unaware that it was the third strike, yelled, "Get 'em on the next pitch, Wally." Manager Stanky happened to be walking by and heard him, and there was an embarrassed silence until Westlake came back to the bench. "You only get three strikes in this league, keed," Westlake said.

(He probably didn't really say, "keed," but the story just sounds better that way.)

Weaver's conversation and zest for the game is welcome in Baltimore because it had gotten to a point where Bauer was almost sprinting out of the clubhouse after a game. Small talk was never Bauer's forte and he almost always was never one to chew the rag when things didn't go well. It was true when he managed; it was so when he was playing with the Yankees.

"Look," said an Oriole ballplayer before last night's game. "Bauer was not a particularly smart baseball man. The club we had in 1966 was a club he could manage because we came through with the big hits. This may be a better all-around team, but some of our big guys haven't been hitting home runs. Weaver may be the right guy at the right place now because he moves. He makes changes; he gets guys in the lineup."

Weaver looked good coming out of the dugout last night to change pitchers in the late innings. He out-manuevered Yankee manager Ralph Houk when he brought in lefty Pete Richert to pitch to lefty pinch-hitter Jake Gibbs. Houk didn't have another regular catcher on hand, so he had to stay with Gibbs. That move didn't pay off for Weaver because Gibbs walked. But when Richert threw a near wild pitch with the bases loaded to the next hitter, Weaver had his pitching coach hustle to the mound and settle the fellow down. Richert got out of the jam.

The Orioles hung on and won with homers in the 10th inning. There's that feeling about them that they are a team which will hold on and continue to whittle games off Detroit's lead. The Tigers' margin is 5½ games now (five in the loss column) and baseball people accept that the Tigers are on the verge of real trouble. They have only one solid starter in Dennis McLain, there have been some panic pitching moves by manager Mayo Smith, and the manager has said things like, "If we play .500 ball the rest of the year . . ." Managers who talk about playing .500 ball are in trouble.

Frank Robinson, the big hitter and fearless talker, feels the spirit. "We're moving now," he said. "We're gonna win it."



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